

Use tech for good, not bad



Jayesh Shinde
Technical Editor –
Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"We see one set of people using technology's benefits to shortchange a different set of people"

Living on the fringe of Mumbai, I rely completely on the public transport system to commute from and to work on a daily basis. I take the suburban train, city bus and auto rickshaw to get to work, and my commutes are fairly boring and without incident. On days when we have to stay back in office till the graveyard shift and close the magazine, I take radio cabs like Meru, Ola and Uber to reach home from office. On these long journeys, I try and have a conversation with the cab drivers, understand how technology is helping them adjust to a whole new reality of commuting in a megacity like Mumbai.

Technology was helping them – the customer and the company – all right. In more ways than one. And not all of them good. Let me explain.

Talking to several radio cab service drivers led to a revelation as to how consumers are trying to game the system. Two words: surge pricing – every app-driven cab hailer's worst nightmare. It's a facet of the service that has attracted a lot of consumer ire, but cab services feel it's their right to be compensated a little more when a consumer's assured a cab amidst surging demand. To counter this practice, consumers have come up with a novel solution. While booking a cab they drop their location pin in an area which isn't in the surge price zone. Upon getting a confirmed cab booking, they then proceed to call the driver and tell them that their phone's GPS is wonky and that they're actually located somewhere else altogether. This is really hard on the drivers as they often have to go out of their way and burn extra fuel to pickup locations. Hope no Digit readers engage in this practice.

Now an example where cab service companies are being a little cheeky when it comes to reassuring customers who've just booked a cab. For example, if a customer sees that estimated arrival time of a cab is three minutes on their phone app, the same pickup locations will appear as 15 minutes away on the driver's mobile dashboard. This incongruity

in arrival time estimates is done on purpose to reassure impatient customers and not lose their business.

I know this may not be a big issue, just some people cutting corners and what's the difference between a few minutes here and there. But my primary concern is why engage in this deception?

Remember unsubstantiated reports from a year or two ago claiming how ecommerce and ticketing websites track users' browser cookies to jack up fare or item prices. What do they say about there being no smoke without a fire?

So far, we had spoken about how in certain cases access to technology was negatively affecting people, whether it involved staring too long at digital screens (like smartphone usage in the dark can render you blind for up to 15 minutes - <http://digit.in/PhoneBlind>) or sitting at a desk without too much exercise. Initially, people were mesmerized by technology's appeal and later they knew for better or worse they were stuck with it.

But now, we see one set of people using technology's benefits to shortchange a different set of people. Intentionally screwing over people through technology malpractice is a lose-lose for both the companies and users, in the long term.

Companies need to be careful, as in the digital age any malpractice will not remain under cover for too long, and at stake is the credibility of the so called sharing (/access) economy. More than encouraging people to accept technology, such negative practices will ensure people continue to remain skeptical of technology's advantages. ■